

CASE ID: 201904710316

EPISODE NAME: Prague Sister City Dispute

2019/04/28 - 2021/01/13

Sender: China (710)

Target: Czech Republic (316)

Issue: Contain Political Influence (1)

Final Outcome: Stalemate after Sanctions Imposition (9)

Summary:

On 2019/04/28, China threatened to cancel a cultural event (the Prague Philharmonic Orchestra's 2019/10 trip to China), after Prague's mayor Zdeněk Hřib refused to adopt policies accepting the "One China" principle. Of particular concern was the municipality's request to remove the "One China" provision in Prague and Beijing's sister city agreement. Hřib's government ultimately canceled the sister city agreement on 2019/10/07 and signed an alternate agreement with Taipei on 2020/01/13, drawing backlash from China.

Narrative:

On 2019/04/28, reports emerged that Beijing was threatening to cancel the Prague Philharmonic Orchestra's 2019/10 trip to China unless the organization formally acknowledged the "One-China" policy.¹ The threat came in response to Prague's mayor, Zdeněk Hřib's unwillingness to comply with Chinese diplomatic norms. In 2019/01, he demanded that the "One-China" acknowledgement clause in the Prague-Beijing sister city agreement be removed.² Hřib also refused to expel the Director of Taipei Economic and Cultural Office in Prague from a New Year's diplomatic celebration.³ In 2019/03, the municipality welcomed the president of the Central Tibetan Administration and the president of Taiwan.^{4 5}

¹ "China threatens to cancel the tour of the Prague Orchestra PKF, annoyed by criticism from Mayor Hřib." *Aktualne*, April 28th, 2019.

<https://zpravy.aktualne.cz/domaci/kvuli-hribove-kritice-rusi-cinane-vystoupeni-ceskych-umelcu/r~7deb62a269ba11e9ad610cc47ab5f122/>.

² Bajerová, Alžběta. "Inside of China's Current Hassle with the 'Rogue' Mayor of Prague." *Choice*, August 1st 2019. <https://chinaobservers.eu/inside-of-chinas-current-hassle-with-the-rogue-mayor-of-prague/>.

³ Tait, Robert. "Zdeněk Hřib: the Czech mayor who defied China." *The Guardian*, July 3rd, 2019. <https://www.theguardian.com/cities/2019/jul/03/zdenek-hrib-the-czech-mayor-who-defied-china-taiwan>.

⁴ "Prague Mayor Gives Symbolic Key to President Sangay – Same Key Given to President Xi." *Central Tibetan Administration*, March 7th, 2019.

<https://tibet.net/prague-mayor-gives-symbolic-key-to-president-sangay-same-key-given-to-president-xi/>.

⁵ "President Tsai meets Prague Mayor Zdeněk Hřib." *Office of the President of the Republic of China (Taiwan)*, March 30th, 2019. <https://english.president.gov.tw/News/5699>.

The Chinese government issued a second threat on 2019/07/18, when Chinese foreign ministry spokesman Geng Shuang said in a news conference Hřib's stance was affecting Sino-Czech relations.⁶ The orchestra did not acquiesce to China's demands, and the trip was cancelled on 2019/07/19, causing the organization a loss of millions of Czech crowns.^{7 8}

Prague's City Hall ultimately voted to cancel the sister city agreement on 2019/10/07, after Beijing refused to re-negotiate the agreement without the "One-China" clause.⁹ In response, China terminated its sister agreement with Prague and suspended official contacts with the city on 2019/10/10.¹⁰ Prague then signed an alternative sister-city agreement with Taipei on 2020/01/13, causing China to respond with a harshly worded statement claiming they would cut ties with the city.¹¹

⁶ Mortkowitz, Siegfried. "Prague mayor's feud with China risks boiling over." Politico, July 18th, 2019. <https://www.politico.eu/article/czech-republic-prague-mayors-feud-with-china-beijing-risks-boiling-over/>.

⁷ Kenety, Brian. "Prague Philharmonic tour of China cancelled over Beijing's row with Czech mayor." *Radio Prague International*, July 19th, 2019.

<https://english.radio.cz/prague-philharmonic-tour-china-cancelled-over-beijings-row-czech-mayor-8125539>.

⁸ Santora, Marc. "The Broken Promise of a Panda: How Prague's Relations With Beijing Soured." *The New York Times*, November 23rd, 2019. <https://www.nytimes.com/2019/11/23/world/europe/china-prague-taiwan.html>.

⁹ "Prague moves to cancel partnership agreement with Beijing." *Associated Press*, October 7th, 2019. <https://apnews.com/general-news-4a3d36807f6e47e3aa9129e272a2861c>.

¹⁰ McEnchroe, Thomas. "China terminates Prague-Beijing sister city agreement." *Radio Prague International*, October 10th, 2019. <https://english.radio.cz/china-terminates-prague-beijing-sister-city-agreement-8118586>.

¹¹ Yeung, Jessie. "Prague's tryst with Taipei sees Shanghai spurned in sister city love triangle." *CNN*, January 15th, 2020. <https://www.politico.eu/article/czech-republic-prague-mayors-feud-with-china-beijing-risks-boiling-over/>.